The Bridge Poem and Women Don't Riot

By Kate Rushin and Ana Castillo

INTRODUCTION

"The disease to please," as psychologist Harriet Braiker likes to call it, is a form of addiction. Just as a drug addict seeks drugs, a people pleaser seeks approval. We should help others and try to make them happy. But, the need to please others at all cost at all times, and be everything to everyone are actions of a desperate person. In these two poems The Bridge Poem by Kate Rushin and Women Don't Riot, we experience the inner turmoil and external consequences facing women who have experienced this disease first hand.

The Bridge Poem

I've had enough

I'm sick of seeing and touching

Both sides of things

Sick of being the damn bridge for everybody

Nobody

4NG Fanatics

Can talk to anybody

Without me

Right?

I explain my mother to my father my father to my little sister

My little sister to my brother my brother to the white feminists

The white feminists to the Black church folks the Black church folks

To the ex-hippies the ex-hippies to the Black separatists the

Black separatists to the artists the artists to my friends' parents...

Then

I've got to explain myself

To everybody

I do more translating

Than the Gawdamn U. N.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Forget it

I'm sick of it

I'm sick of filling in your gaps

Sick of being your insurance against

The isolation of your self-imposed limitations

Sick of being the crazy at your holiday dinners

Sick of being the odd one at your Sunday Brunches

Sick of being the sole Black friend to 34 individual white people

Find another connection to the rest of the world

Find something else to make you legitimate

Find some other way to be political and hip

I will not be the bridge to your womanhood

Your manhood

Your human-ness

4NG Fanatics

I'm sick of reminding you not to

Close off too tight for too long

I'm sick of mediating with your worst self

On behalf of your better selves

I am sick

Of having to remind you

To breathe

Before you suffocate

Your own fool self

Forget it

Stretch or drown

Evolve or die

The bridge I must be

Is the bridge to my own power

I must translate

My own fears

Mediate

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

My own weaknesses

I must be the bridge to nowhere
But my true self
And then
I will be useful

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kate Rushin
Book: This Bridge Called My Back
ISBN: 978-0913175033
Publisher: Kitchen Table--Women of Color Press
Date (Month/Year): February 1, 1984

Women Don't Riot

Women don't riot, not in maquilas in Malaysia, Mexico, or
Korea,
not in sweatshops in New York or El Paso.
They don't revolt
in kitchens, laundries, or nurseries.

4NG Fanatics

Not by the hundreds or thousands, changing
sheets in hotels or in laundries
when scalded by hot water,
not in restaurants where they clean and clean
and clean their hands raw.

Women don't riot, not sober and earnest,
or high and strung out, not of any color,
any race, not the rich, poor,
or those in between. And mothers of all kinds
especially don't run rampant through the streets.

In college those who've thought it out
join hands in crucial times, carry signs,
are dragged away in protest.
We pass out petitions, organize a civilized vigil,
return to work the next day.

We women are sterilized, have more children
than they can feed,
don't speak the official language,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

want things they see on TV,
would like to own a TV--
women who were molested as children
raped,
beaten,
harassed, which means
every last one sooner or later;
women who've defended themselves
and women who can't or don't know how
we don't--won't ever rise up in arms.

We don't storm through cities,
take over the press, make a unified statement,
once and for all: A third-millennium call--
from this day on no more, not me, not my daughter,
not her daughter either.

Women don't form a battalion, march arm in arm
across continents bound
by the same tongue, same food or lack thereof,
same God, same abandonment,

4NG Fanatics

same broken heart,
raising children on our own, have
so much endless misery in common
that must stop
not for one woman or every woman,
but for the sake of us all.

Quietly, instead, one and each takes the offense,
rejection, bureaucratic dismissal, disease
that should not have been, insult,
shove, blow to the head,
a knife at her throat.
She won't fight, she won't even scream--
taught as she's been
to be brought down as if by surprise.
She'll die like an ant beneath a passing heel.
Today it was her. Next time who.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ana Castillo
Book: I Ask the Impossible
ISBN: 978-0385720731
Publisher: Anchor Books
Date (Month/Year): March 2001

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY